launched by a British rocket. The UK continues to be dependent on NASA for its satellite launches.

It was around this time that Sarabhai, ostensibly knowing my fixation with liquid systems, asked me to visit a Rolls Royce space science facility, which would soon be dismantled as part of the UK's decision to shelve its active space programme. The facility at Spadeadam in Cumbria, had a new hydraulics laboratory the company had put up at 400 million pounds. A F Cleaver, the director of the Rolls Royce lab was a former British army officer who had served in Mumbai. Cleaver said he never agreed with the way his country looted mine, and wanted to give back whatever little he could.

'What can I give you?' he asked.

I felt like a child in a toy supermarket. I wanted everything I saw around.

'Why don't you give me this hydraulics lab?' I said.

The lab, which offered simulation test for fluids with a complex system of gauges, was any fluid dynamics engineer's dream place.

Cleaver remained pensive for a moment, then said, 'You mean your scientists want to come here and do experiments? But the problem is we are going to break this down soon.'

'What if I ship this out?'

No sooner had I blurted out my request, I wondered if I was being too audacious.

'Do you mean what you said,' Cleaver's face lit up. 'It would be fantastic if you could do that. It is better that India put this to good use than us dumping it.'

Cleaver said he was feeling guilty that Britain did not allow India to partake in the industrial revolution, and found this an opportunity to pay back, however minor this contribution would be. He said he would give the entire hardware free of cost, only that India had to pay for dismantling the set-up and shipping it out. Here was a 400 million-pound lab, all ours, if we could disassemble, ship and reassemble it. I had no idea where I would find space in India to set this up, but I nodded vigorously.